FREE FIRST.
PAID BY CHOICE.

Run useful AI without making every task a paid API call.

01 **SCRIPT**

A normal tool can solve it? Skip the LLM.

02 **LOCAL**

Private data or a small job? Use your hardware.

03 **FREE CLOUD**

Use a capable, verified zero-price model.

04 **PAID: ASK FIRST**

Only by choice, or a bounded preapproved exception.

Free cloud can be your daily default. Local is optional, not a mandatory extra hop.

INSTALL HERMES

Start with the official app. Free cloud does not need a powerful GPU.

1 / DOWNLOAD

Open the official website and follow the installation steps for your operating system.

hermes-agent.nousresearch.com

2 / SET UP

Run the setup wizard, then check that Hermes starts correctly.

```
hermes setup
hermes doctor
```

Already installed? Back up your active configuration first. Apply changes to the intended profile only.

Official installation instructions →

CONNECT A FREE MODEL

Use your own OpenRouter account and API key.

- **CREATE YOUR KEY**

  Open openrouter.ai/settings/keys. Enter the key in Hermes provider setup — never in a chat.

```
hermes model
```

Choose OpenRouter, then select a currently free, tool-capable model.

STARTER MODEL / CATALOG-CHECKED

nvidia/nemotron-3-ultra-550b-a55b:free

EASY ALTERNATIVE

openrouter/free selects from eligible free models. It is NOT the same as openrouter/auto.

openrouter.ai/models?pricing=free

Start a new chat after setting your default. Free availability can change.

FREE-ONLY BACKUPS

A free primary with a paid fallback can still generate a bill.

```
hermes fallback
hermes fallback list
```

ADD ONLY VERIFIED FREE / LOCAL ROUTES

For example: poolside/laguna-s-2.1:free or openrouter/free through OpenRouter.

- **SERVICE FAILURE ≠ WRONG ANSWER**

  Fallback reacts to API errors. It does not determine whether an answer is correct.

- **QUOTA EXHAUSTED?**

  Wait, use local, or ask. Another model can share the same daily account limit.

Never put a paid model at the end “just in case.” Check upstream proxies and old fallback_model settings too.

Fallback setup and behavior →

KEEP PRIVATE WORK LOCAL

No hosted inference bill. Your hardware, electricity and memory still matter.

DESKTOP PATH

Settings → Providers → Local Models. Click Install runtime.

- **DOWNLOAD A MODEL THAT FITS**

  Choose tool support and realistic memory fit, not just the biggest model name.

- **CLICK USE + TEST A REAL TOOL CALL**

  A fluent chat reply does not prove the model can execute tools.

ALREADY HAVE OLLAMA?

Reuse it. The usual endpoint is http://127.0.0.1:11434/v1 — verify your actual port.

Local-only means local auxiliary calls and no cloud fallback. Keep unauthenticated servers off the internet.

Official Local Models guide →

CHECK THE HIDDEN CALLS

Your main chat model is only one place that can spend money.

- **CRON + SUBAGENTS**

  Pin free/local models independently. Audit existing jobs and worker overrides.

- **AUXILIARY MODELS**

  Check compression, titles, vision and approvals. “Auto” may follow a paid chat model.

- **PLUGINS + TOOL APIs**

  Search, images, speech, cloud browsers and memory services can bill separately.

CHEAPEST AUTOMATION

Use a script-only no-agent job for deterministic checks. Do not wake an LLM just to compare files.

Inspect models and auxiliary settings →

Free quotas are finite. One agent task can consume many API requests.

NO SILENT PAID UPGRADE.

Recommended mode: ask before spending. Free-route failure is not permission.

COPY THIS RULE

Use tools, local, then free models. Paid models require my explicit permission. Keep automatic fallbacks free/local. Verify results.

- **IF YOU AUTHORIZE A PAID STEP**

  Name the model, scope and budget. Enforce the cap with the provider or a budget-aware dispatcher.

- **JEV IS OPTIONAL**

  It can advise retry / stop / escalate. Hosted API use may cost money.

CONFIDENCE IS NOT CONSENT

A gate threshold of 0.90 is a policy choice, not spending permission or proof of accuracy. No reliable gate? Ask.

TEST IT.
THEN SHARE IT.

Do not trust a model simply claiming that it is free or local.

ASK IN AN EMPTY TEST DIRECTORY

Use a terminal or file tool to list this directory. Report the actual tool result. Do not modify files.

- **CHECK THE ACTUAL ROUTE**

  Look at Hermes provider/model metadata and openrouter.ai/activity. Review any charges.

USEFUL LINKS / CLICK IN THE PDF

Hermes documentation

Free models + current pricing

OpenRouter limits and quotas

Check provider activity

Share images 01–08 as one album, or forward the PDF. Never share API keys or private logs.

Free cloud sends data to third parties. Availability and quotas change. Full commands are in the companion text guide.